

# Current Programme

## Gesualdo / Take 6 — Vocal Harmony Without Voices

### Format

Start: **20:30**

Nominal music duration: **27:40**

Realistic performed music duration: **30–32 min**

With transitions and short spoken islands: **36–38 min**

Total spoken introduction / discussion: **20–22 min**

Total event: **58–60 min**

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## Concept

This conference-concert is built around a paradox:

vocal music without voices.

Gesualdo's madrigals and sacred pieces were written for five or six voices. Take 6 works in a completely different idiom — gospel, jazz, pop, studio vocal virtuosity — but also from the same miracle: several independent human voices forming a single harmonic body.

The string quartet cannot reproduce the words, the breath, or the vocal blend of the originals. But it can reveal something else: the harmonic skeleton, the counterpoint, the inner tensions, the architecture of dissonance and resolution.

The question of the evening is therefore:

What remains of vocal music when the voices disappear and only four strings are left?

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## Programme

| # | Piece                                        | Original voices | Duration | Function                        |
|---|----------------------------------------------|-----------------|----------|---------------------------------|
| 1 | Carlo Gesualdo, <i>Luci serene e chiare</i>  | 5               | 2:59     | Opening light, already unstable |
| 2 | Carlo Gesualdo, <i>Dolcissima mia vita</i>   | 5               | 2:15     | Sweetness, intimacy, fragility  |
| 3 | Carlo Gesualdo, <i>Già piansi nel dolore</i> | 5               | 2:37     | Grief as harmonic motion        |

| #  | Piece                                            | Original voices | Duration     | Function                           |
|----|--------------------------------------------------|-----------------|--------------|------------------------------------|
| 4  | Carlo Gesualdo, <i>S'io non miro non moro</i>    | 5               | 2:00         | Paradox, desire, compression       |
| 5  | Take 6, <i>Come Unto Me</i>                      | 6 vocal parts   | 2:13 nominal | First modern mirror: sacred warmth |
| 6  | Carlo Gesualdo, <i>Moro, lasso, al mio duolo</i> | 5               | 2:58         | Central shock: chromatic death     |
| 7  | Carlo Gesualdo, <i>Sparge la morte</i>           | 5               | 2:49         | Death as dispersion                |
| 8  | Carlo Gesualdo, <i>Beltà, poi che t'assenti</i>  | 5               | 2:11         | Beauty as absence                  |
| 9  | Carlo Gesualdo, <i>Tristis est anima mea</i>     | 6               | 3:00         | Sacred darkness                    |
| 10 | Take 6, <i>Hark! The Herald Angels Sing</i>      | 6 vocal parts   | 2:40 nominal | Radiant sacred interruption        |
| 11 | Take 6, <i>A Quiet Place</i>                     | 6 vocal parts   | 1:58 nominal | Quiet resolution                   |

**Nominal music total: 27:40**

## Dramatic shape

### Arc I — Light, sweetness, wound

#### 1. Gesualdo — *Luci serene e chiare*

**Five voices — 2:59**

The concert begins with light: serene, clear, sensual. But in Gesualdo, light is never entirely stable. Already, beauty is bent by chromatic tension.

**Listening key:** hear how brightness becomes harmonic instability.

#### 2. Gesualdo — *Dolcissima mia vita*

**Five voices — 2:15**

A piece of tenderness and intimacy. But Gesualdo's sweetness is never simple. The music constantly disturbs its own surface.

**Listening key:** listen for the fracture inside sweetness.

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### 3. Gesualdo — *Già piansi nel dolore*

**Five voices — 2:37**

Grief becomes a succession of harmonic events. The pain is not painted from outside; it is produced by the movement of the lines.

**Listening key:** listen to sorrow as voice-leading.

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### 4. Gesualdo — *S'io non miro non moro*

**Five voices — 2:00**

A paradox of seeing, living, and dying. The madrigal compresses desire and contradiction into a very small harmonic space.

This piece also connects directly to Bruno Mantovani's *Time Stretch (on Gesualdo)*, which takes *S'io non miro non moro* as its source.

**Listening key:** hear the madrigal as a compressed harmonic machine.

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## Arc II — The impossible body of harmony

### 5. Take 6 — *Come Unto Me*

**Six vocal parts — 2:13 nominal**

The first modern mirror. Take 6 comes from another world — gospel, jazz, studio vocal virtuosity — but the underlying question is related: what can several voices do together that no single voice can do alone?

**Listening key:** hear the quartet trying to remember six human voices.

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### 6. Gesualdo — *Moro, lasso, al mio duolo*

**Five voices — 2:58**

The emotional and harmonic center of the programme. The famous chromatic descent is not merely expressive; it feels physical, as if pain were pulling the music downward.

**Listening key:** hear the descent as an anatomy of suffering.

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## 7. Gesualdo — *Sparge la morte*

Five voices — 2:49

After the concentrated shock of *Moro, lasso*, death becomes dispersed. The affect spreads through the texture.

**Listening key:** listen to death moving from line to line.

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## 8. Gesualdo — *Beltà, poi che t'assenti*

Five voices — 2:11

Beauty is no longer presence, but withdrawal. The music seems suspended around absence.

This piece is also one of the three madrigals Stravinsky recomposed instrumentally in *Monumentum pro Gesualdo*.

**Listening key:** hear beauty as disappearance.

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## Arc III — Sacred darkness, radiant interruption, quiet resolution

### 9. Gesualdo — *Tristis est anima mea*

Six voices — 3:00

The programme moves from madrigal pain into sacred darkness. Personal suffering becomes liturgical sorrow.

**Listening key:** hear how the sacred does not remove pain; it gives it another space.

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### 10. Take 6 — *Hark! The Herald Angels Sing*

Six vocal parts — 2:40 nominal

This is the new luminous pivot near the end of the programme.

After Gesualdo's *Tristis est anima mea*, the familiar Christmas carol returns the evening to sacred music, but through joy rather than sorrow. In Take 6's language, the carol becomes a display of six-part harmonic brilliance: radiant, festive, precise, and modern.

Placed here, it prevents the ending from becoming only dark. It introduces glory, brightness, and collective celebration before the final pacification of *A Quiet Place*.

**Listening key:** hear sacred harmony turning from lament to radiance.

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## 11. Take 6 — *A Quiet Place*

Six vocal parts — 1:58 nominal

The final piece should not feel like an encore, but like a resolution.

After Gesualdo's chromatic pain and Take 6's radiant carol, *A Quiet Place* brings the programme to rest. The harmony remains complex, but the affect has changed: no longer torment, but consolation.

**Listening key:** hear complexity becoming peace.

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## Spoken structure

### Spoken Island 1 — Opening

3–4 minutes

- Vocal music without voices.
- Gesualdo, Take 6, and the string quartet.
- The quartet as an X-ray of vocal harmony.
- One sentence only on Gesualdo's biography.

### Spoken Island 2 — After piece 2 or before piece 3

3–4 minutes

- What is a madrigal?
- A theatre of voices.
- Words become harmonic events.

### Spoken Island 3 — Before Take 6, *Come Unto Me*

3–4 minutes

- Why Take 6 belongs here.
- Not contrast, but modern mirror.
- Six voices as harmonic organism.

### Spoken Island 4 — Before *Moro, lasso*

4–5 minutes

- The central shock.
- Gesualdo's chromatic descent.
- Gesualdo's later reception: Huxley, Stravinsky, Mantovani, Akchoté, Brett Dean.

## Spoken Island 5 — Before *Tristis est anima mea* or before *Hark!*

4-5 minutes

- From madrigal to sacred darkness.
  - Then from sacred darkness to sacred radiance.
  - Prepare the final Take 6 sequence: *Hark!* as glory, *A Quiet Place* as repose.
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## Possible closing formulation before the final two Take 6 pieces

After Gesualdo's sacred darkness, we do not end with darkness. We turn toward another sacred world: Take 6, where six voices produce not torment but light. *Hark! The Herald Angels Sing* brings radiance; *A Quiet Place* brings rest. The evening ends, then, not by resolving Gesualdo, but by placing beside him another possibility of complex vocal harmony: harmony as consolation.